



HackIllinois 2026 Attendee Guide

Welcome!

Thank you for participating in HackIllinois 2026! Before you launch into your cosmic journey, review this Astronaut's Guide to Mission Control to help you navigate uncharted galaxies, conquer challenges, and chart a course toward innovation and glory.

The guide is meant to serve as a comprehensive overview of the hackathon. It will cover the vital information you need to know for the event. Additionally, use the table of contents to quickly navigate each section and prepare for liftoff!

We hope this guide answers any questions you might have, but feel free to send a message on Discord or send us an email at contact@hackillinois.org if you have any questions! You can also visit hackillinois.org for more information such as our **FAQ section**, **schedule**, and **mentor/judge bios**.

Note that all times on this document are in CST (GMT - 6:00).

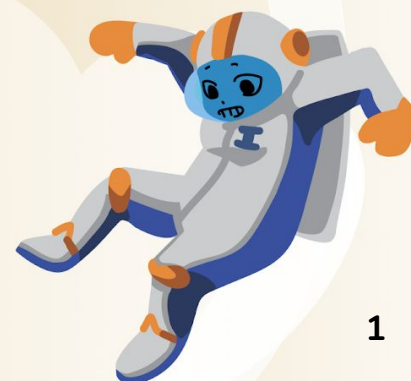


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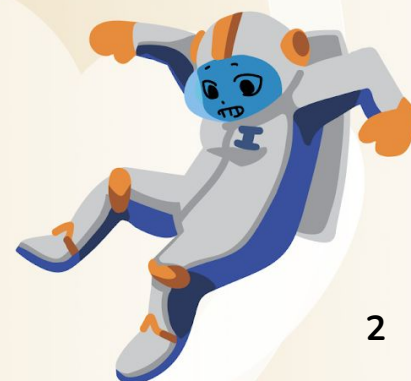
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About the Event

HackIllinois 2026 is a fully in-person 36-hour-long hackathon running from February 27th to March 1st. During this time, attendees are challenged to build a software project while learning development skills from industry-led workshops and expert mentors.

Before the Event

To-dos

Join our [Discord](#)! If you RSVPed, you should have received an invitation link via email. We will be sending out announcements through Discord, and you can also use our channels to talk to other attendees, network and ask staff any questions!

Download our app! Make sure to download the HackIllinois app ahead of time and **sign-in as an attendee using your GitHub account** — this will streamline the check-in process and make it faster for you to get started with our event! The HackIllinois App is available on both the [Apple App Store](#) and the [Google Play Store](#).

Packing List:

- Student ID
- Reusable water bottle (we will NOT be providing water bottles)
- Laptops & chargers
- Extension Cord
- Warm clothes + change of clothing
- Personal items such as toiletries
- Medication – if needed
- An umbrella (just in case)

Due to safety considerations, DO NOT bring power-heavy, dangerous, or illegal items, including, but not limited to,

- Desktop computers
- Extra monitors
- Weapons
- Alcoholic beverages, drugs, and other illicit substances





Event Infrastructure

Location

HackIllinois will be at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (UIUC) in [Thomas M. Siebel Center for Computer Science](#). Check-in begins at 2:00 PM on Friday, February 27th in front of the ACM Room (1104). A map of Siebel can be accessed [here](#). Parking information can be found [here](#).



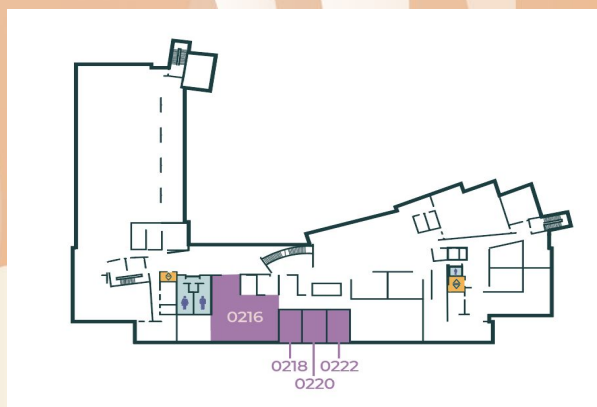
Building Closing and Opening Times

The Siebel Center for CS will close at 1:00 AM every night and will reopen at 7:00 AM. **There will not be sleeping lounges available in Siebel Center for CS after closing times. HackIllinois will not maintain any presence in the building during closed hours.**

The Siebel Center for CS doors lock at 9:30 PM.

You must have an iCard with swipe access to enter the building after.

DO NOT PROP OPEN ANY BUILDING DOORS – please help us keep Hack attendees, staff, and their belongings safe. Attendees caught propping doors open are subject to removal from event.



Event Infrastructure

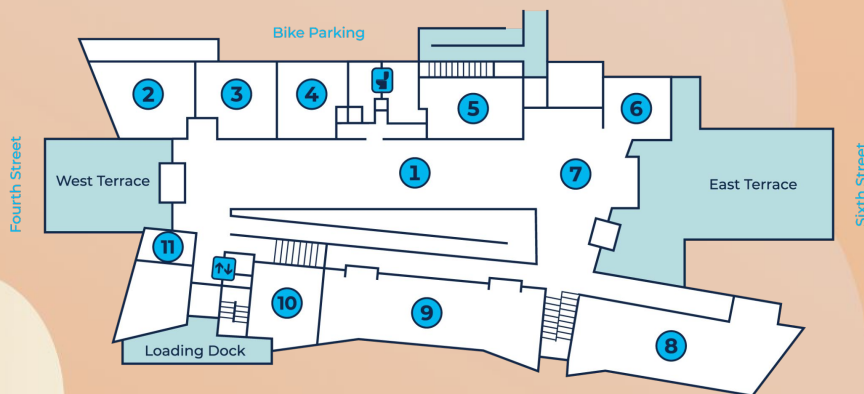
Location

HackIllinois will provide overnight hacking spaces at [Siebel Center for Design](#).

The overnight space is intended for hackers who want to continue working throughout the night. That said, we will also have a designated quiet/rest area if you'd like to take a short break or nap but HackIllinois will **not** provide sleeping materials. If you prefer more traditional lodging, we highly recommend booking a nearby hotel.

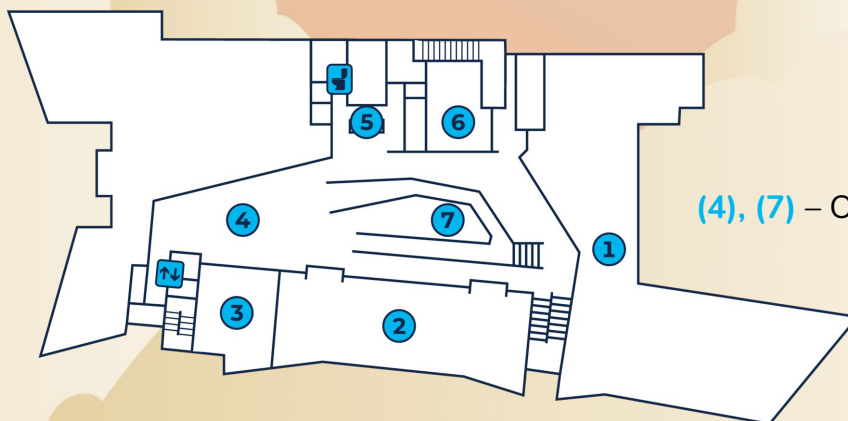
Note: only staff can open the building doors after midnight. If you would like to re-enter, please let us know before leaving.

Main Floor

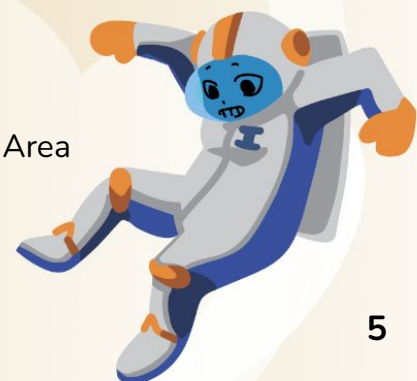


- (11) – Helpdesk
- (9) Sunset Studio – working space
- (8) Sunrise Studio – quiet working space
- (1), (6), (7) – Open Working Area

Lower Floor



- (4), (7) – Open Working Area



Apps

The HackIllinois App

The HackIllinois App is available for download on both the [Apple App Store](#) and the [Google Play Store](#). It'll display the schedule, help you scan codes for points, and redeem those points for items at our Point Shop (read more below)!

Note: You get points by attending mini-events, workshops, and company showcases. Points translate into prizes! Learn more in the [Points Section](#).

HackIllinois Social Media

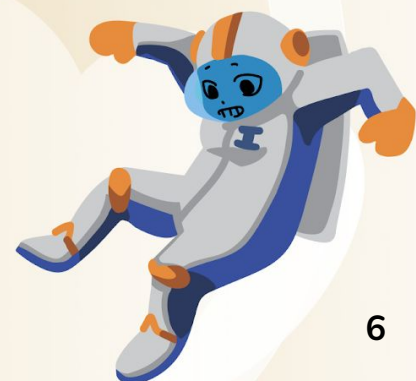
Follow the HackIllinois [Instagram](#) to learn more about HackIllinois. You'll get an opportunity to see the work that goes into making the event a possibility through insights from teams, behind the scenes footage, and more!

Discord

You can use our [Discord](#) server to communicate with attendees and company representatives, get help from mentors, and receive event reminders. To join our server, please check your email—you should have received an invite if you RSVPed! Accept our Terms and Conditions and you'll be good to go!

Wi-Fi

If you do not attend UIUC, please use the "IllinoisNet-Guest" network. When you connect, a browser window will open and prompt you for information.



Check-In

Check-in for HackIllinois will be on the first floor atrium of the Siebel Center for Computer Science building on Friday, February 27th from 2:00 PM - 5:00 PM. If you are unable to check in during this time, you are free to go to the check-in desk any time during HackIllinois.

Please download the HackIllinois app ahead of time and sign in as an attendee using your GitHub account — this will streamline the check-in process and make it faster for you to get started with our event! As you approach the front of the check-in line, please pull up your profile on the HackIllinois app to show to the staff checking you in.

Event Schedule

HackIllinois is excited to present a large variety of events, including technical workshops, fun mini-events, and thrilling game-based challenges. You can find the schedule for this weekend on our [website](#) and our app!

Food Waves

Each attendee will be assigned a Wave (1 or 2) that can be viewed on the app. We will be calling up attendees by their wave number to receive meals, and you will receive a notification on the HackIllinois app when your Wave is being called up. A dietary and allergen information guide will be linked in the app prior to each meal and will include details for all food being served throughout the weekend.



MLH Resources

This year, HackIllinois is proud to partner with Major League Hacking (MLH) to help support you throughout the weekend! MLH is the official student hackathon league and will be providing resources, mentorship, and support to ensure you have an amazing experience.

Here's how you can connect with MLH during HackIllinois:

- **On Discord:** Visit the **#ask-mlh** channel to ask questions and get support.
- **MLH Help Desk:** Find an MLH representative in person in the First Floor Atrium.
- **Hardware Hub:** Located next to the MLH Help Desk, it offers materials for Mechathon participants. You can find the full list of available hardware [here](#).
 - Please note: Supplies may be limited. We strongly encourage you to check out only materials you need *early* rather than waiting until the last minute.

All participants are expected to follow the MLH Code of Conduct, which helps ensure a safe, welcoming, and inclusive environment for everyone.



Team Guidelines

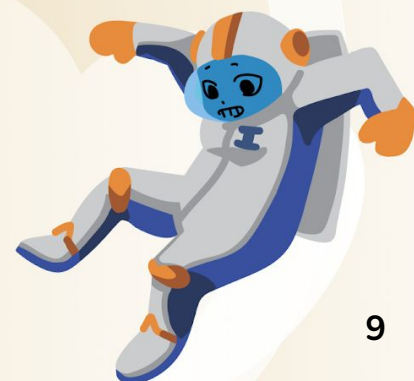
The guidelines for team formation are as follows:

- Teams can have up to **4 members**. Note that you do not need a team to compete, although we strongly recommend hacking with others for the best Hackathon experience!
- All team members **must be accepted, RSVPed, and checked in**.
- Teams need to be finalized by end of **Friday, February 27th**. If your team has at least 1 general attendee, then your submission will automatically be considered for the **General Path**. However, all teams may still compete for Company Sponsored Tracks.

Creating a team is as simple as asking a friend to join your project. We also have a team formations channel on Discord and will host an in-person team matching event to help you look for teammates. You must submit the team confirmation form by 28th

Date & Time	Event	Location
February 27th, 8:30 PM - 9:30 PM	Team Matching	Siebel Center for Computer Science 0218

When you submit your project through Devpost, make sure to add every teammate to your project submission so that we can award them prizes! **We cannot award prizes to people who are not on the Devpost submission.**



Paths

When you were accepted to HackIllinois, you were admitted as either a **HackVoyager** or a **General** attendee. This is your **Path**. By submitting a project, you are eligible to win the prize designated for your respective Path. Note: If your team has at least 1 general attendee, then your team submission will automatically be considered for the General path.

Path Prizes

Path	Prize
General	\$2,500
HackVoyagers	\$5,000

Tracks

You can also submit to a **Track** by tailoring your project to a theme or guideline provided by our company sponsors. Tracks are **optional** and your project does not need to fall under the scope of one. That being said, building and submitting a Track project qualifies you for that Track prize *in addition* to your Path prize!

Note: Each project may only submit to **AT MOST ONE** Track. If you submit the project to multiple Tracks, the team will be disqualified.

This year, HackIllinois 2026 is proud to announce tracks sponsored by Stripe, Modal, Caterpillar, and John Deere!

Detailed Track Info: <https://go.hackillinois.org/tracks>



HackIllinois Prizes

In addition to our path and track prizes, we have:

- Best Beginner Hack: All beginner teams (at least half of the members are first time hackers) are automatically considered.
- Most Popular: Determined by attendee voting on Devpost.

Participants may submit to up to **2** of the following categories:

- Best Social
- Best UI/UX
- Most Creative
- Most Useless

Company & MLH Prizes

Participants may submit to up to **5** of the following categories:

- Best Use of Cloudflare Developer Platform
- Best Use of OpenAI API
- Best Use of Capital One Nessie (API)
- Best Use of Supermemory
- Best Use of Solana
- Best Use of Action VectorAI DB
- Best Deployed on Aedify
- Best Use of Gemini API
- Best Use of ElevenLabs
- Best Use of Snowflake API
- Best Use of DigitalOcean
- Best Use of Presage
- Best .Tech Domain Name

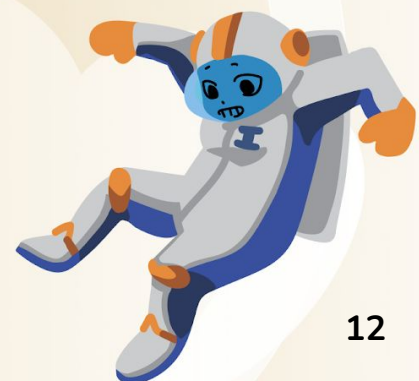
Full Prize List: <https://go.hackillinois.org/prizes>



Prayer Accommodations

A room will be reserved throughout the hackathon as a dedicated prayer and reflection space for all attendees. Participants are encouraged to use the room for religious observance, prayer, and spiritual practices in a quiet and respectful environment. The space may also be used for meditation or brief personal reflection, but its primary purpose is to support the religious needs of attendees during the event. No sign-up is required, anyone may enter when needed, and we kindly ask everyone to help preserve a peaceful, accommodating atmosphere.

- **Siebel Center for CS:** Room 2124
- **Siebel Center for Design:** TBD



Project Requirements and Submission

Submitting Your Project

Use the **HackIllinois Devpost** to submit your project!

Submission Checklist

To qualify for submissions, you will need to meet these criteria:

- Everyone on your team **must be registered, RSVPed, and checked in for HackIllinois.**
- You must submit your project before the submission deadline (**Sunday, March 1st at 6:00 AM CST**).
 - We recommend submitting earlier so that you don't miss the deadline. Late submissions will not be accepted.
- You must be registered with only **one team**.
- Your team must have **four members or less**.
- Your project must have been created **during the 36 hours of the event**.
- Your project must have only been submitted to HackIllinois 2026.
- **At least one team member** must be physically present at the **Project Showcase** to demo the project.
- **All team members** must be physically present for the **HackVoyagers Shark Tank** presentation unless prior approval has been granted via email by **Friday, February 27th**.
- Your project submission on Devpost must contain a public GitHub Repository, a video demo or presentation video (made unlisted or public) that is no longer than 3 minutes, and a description addressing the respective track.

Failure to adhere to these may result in disqualification; final discretion lies with HackIllinois staff. If you are unsure about anything related to Devpost Project Submission, please contact us through contact@hackillinois.org or the Help Desk role on Discord!

Judging Overview

Track & Path Judging

Attendees must present at the Project Showcase to be eligible for a path prize. The General Path, HackVoyagers Path, Company Tracks, and additional prizes will be judged by a science fair-type project showcase.

Inspired by the hit TV series Shark Tank, the HackVoyager Showcase is focused on promoting entrepreneurship in technology by having top 8 HackVoyager teams pitch their project to a panel of judges.

The HackVoyager Showcase will take place at Room 0216, and it will be streamed to watch. The link will be shared closer to the event.

Note: All group members must be HackVoyagers for the project to qualify for the HackVoyager Showcase.

Structure

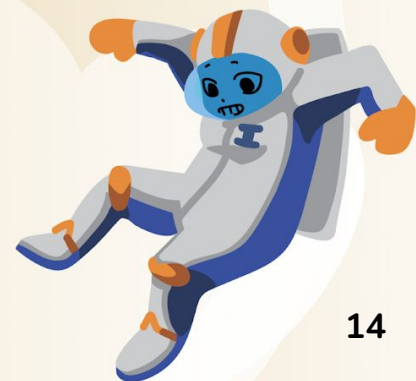
6 AM: Devpost Submission – After submitting your Devpost at 6:00 AM, please **check your email and Discord regularly**, as communication regarding your room allocation and other instructions will be sent through the channels.

9:00 AM – 11:30 AM: Devpost Track Judging (General + HackVoyagers)
During the Project Showcase, teams will present their project and answer any brief questions judges may have for a maximum of 5 minutes. **At least one team member must be physically present** to demo the project.

12:30 PM - 1:30 PM: HackVoyagers Shark Tank (Sponsored by Fulcrum) & Project Showcase Continued

All team members must be physically present for the HackVoyagers Shark Tank presentation unless prior approval has been granted via email by **Friday, February 27th**.

2:00 PM - 3:00 PM: Closing Ceremony (Awards)



Judging & Criteria

Judging is based on four criteria:

- **Idea & Creativity**

Judges will evaluate the originality and thoughtfulness of your concept. Strong projects introduce a novel twist, combine ideas in unexpected ways, or approach a problem in a way that stands out and demonstrates “out of the box”.

- **Product Design**

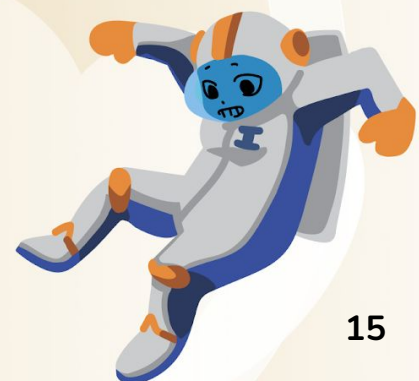
Judges will assess usability, user flow, and visual clarity. The best projects are intuitive, accessible, and thoughtfully designed so users can understand and interact with them without extensive explanation.

- **Execution and Technical Quality**

Judges will consider how well your project works and the quality of your implementation. Projects should function reliably, demonstrate technical skill, and reflect sound engineering decisions within the hackathon timeframe.

- **Impact & Intent**

Judges will evaluate the clarity of your project’s purpose and its value to users. Strong submissions clearly address a real problem, meaningful need, or intentional statement.



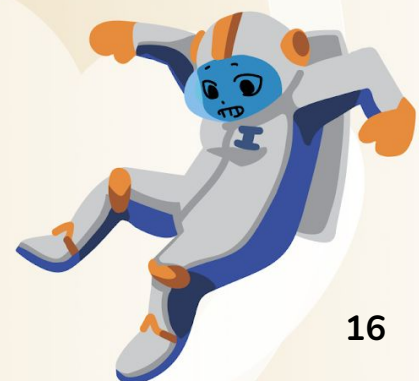
Project Showcase

HackIllinois' Project Showcase is akin to a science fair. You will have the opportunity to showcase your innovative projects to our esteemed judges!

Note: **ALL TEAMS** (regardless of HackVoyager or General) that have submitted a project will present **in-person** during the **Project Showcase**

Format

1. Plan to arrive at the event location at least 15 minutes (8:45 AM) before the official start time so that we can go over the showcase format. **If you arrive over 10 minutes past the official start time, your project will be disqualified and removed from final consideration.**
2. Each team will receive your room assignment and team number via email on **Sunday morning** so please be on the lookout.
3. During this 120-minute time period, you can present your projects to judges and receive feedback for your project. Please limit your presentation to 5 minutes:
 - a. You will have 3 minutes to present your project. After 3 minutes, we will ask you to wrap up your presentation within two sentences.
 - b. The judging panel may conduct a 2-minute Q&A session following the presentation.



Top 8 HackVoyagers Pitch

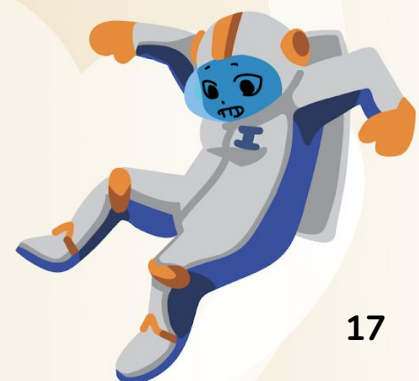
Inspired by the hit TV series Shark Tank, the Top 8 HackVoyagers Pitch is focused on promoting entrepreneurship in technology by having teams pitch their HackIllinois project to a panel of judges. Moreover, **in the past, our company sponsors have reached out to standout Shark Tank presenters to further invest in and develop their projects!**

Note: All group members *must* be HackVoyager for the project to qualify for the HackVoyager Showcase. Groups with a mix of HackVoyager and General members will present at the Project Showcase.

Note: Teams selected to be a part of HackVoyager Project Showcase will be notified by **11:30 AM Sunday, March 1st** via email.

Format

1. Plan to arrive at **Siebel 0216** at least 15 minutes before the official start time so that we can go over the presentation format and requirements.
2. You will be given up to **10 minutes** to present to judges and receive feedback for your project.
 - a. You will have approximately 7 minutes to pitch your project. After 3 minutes, we will ask you to wrap up your presentation within two sentences.
 - b. The judging panel will conduct a 3-minute Q&A session following the presentation.
3. Your presentation materials may include anything that can be projected and shared as a link. Still, keep in mind that time is limited and too many presentation materials will take up time!



Mentoring

During HackIllinois 2026, you might need to seek some technical help and advice from mentors.

Our mentors provide technical advice and help attendees in-person and virtually. Stay tuned on our website for more information about each mentor including their background and skills!

Mentor Office Hours

- Link to Mentor Office Hour Schedule
- In-person mentors will be located in **Siebel 2406**, and you may ask any of them for assistance on your projects.
- You may ask for help in the **#office-hours-text** Discord Channel by using the @Mentor tag.
 - When you receive a response from a mentor, you should then proceed to use one of the Mentor Room Voice Channels or direct message with your mentor to chat privately.
- You can earn 50 points the **first time** you consult with a mentor by asking them to show their scannable QR code .

We ask that you be gracious and patient when seeking help from mentors. Our mentors have kindly volunteered their time to help attendees have a meaningful experience at HackIllinois. **No abusive language directed at our mentors will be tolerated and doing so will result in disqualification from participating in HackIllinois 2026.**



Points

Earning Points

Attendees can engage in workshops, mini-events, and other activities to earn points! Here is a breakdown of all possible ways to earn points at HackIllinois 2026, but you can also check the schedule on our website or app for the point values of attending specific events!

Event/Activity	Point Value
Company Expo / RSP Expo	10 points per company booth
Workshops / Tech Talks / Track Intro	75 points
Mentor Office Hours	50 points (redeemable once)
Solar Search	50 points per booth x 4 booths
Cosmic Challenge	10 points per task x 6 tasks
Astral Exhibition	25 points per booth (except solar soccer 50 pts)
Poker / Clash Royale Tournament	50 points each
Side Quests	20 points each
Duels	2 points → lose, 5 points → win, cap 75 points



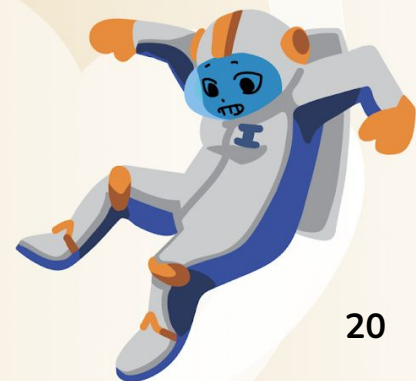
Redeeming Points

Attendees can exchange points for exciting items and raffle tickets at the Point Shop (located by the ACM Office Room 1104). You can reserve an item by purchasing it via the app and showing the given QR code at the Help Desk.

Point Shop Items

Check out the Point Shop on our app to see available items and their prices!

Items	Price (Points)	Items	Price (Points)
Mission Fuel		Lego Space Shuttle	470
Rock Candy / Fruit Snacks / Bars	30	Astronaut Mugs	650
Chips	50	Celestial Tech	
Chicken Ramen	100	JBL Speaker	920
Alien Artifacts		XBOX Console	880
Aliens Smiskies	30	Lamp Projector	880
Temporary Tattoos	40	LED Lights	770
HackIllinois Specialties		Digi Camera	1100
Past Hack Stickers	15	Test Of Fate - Raffles	
Past Hack T-Shirt	50	LED Floor Lamp	100
Cosmic Comfort		Instant Pot	230
Plushie (star, moon, alien)	370	Ninja AirFryer	230
Space Blanket	570	Apple HomePod mini	130



Where and When?

Location: Next to the Help Desk, near the ACM Office, Siebel 1st Floor

Opens: February 27th, 6:00 PM

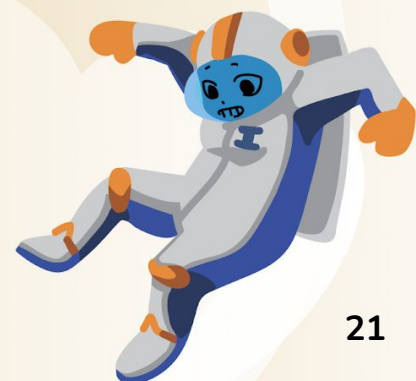
Closes: March 1st, 10:30 AM

*Point shop closes at 1:00 AM every night and reopens at 9:00 AM the next day

Engagement Raffle

Points accumulated throughout the event count towards your Tier. Higher Tiers are eligible for better prizes through a raffle. Engagement Raffle winners will be announced at the **Closing Ceremony**. Prizes will **ONLY** be distributed in person **Sunday March 1, 3–3:30 PM** at the Help Desk.

Gold Tier	Silver Tier
Sony XM5	\$150 Steam Gift Cards
LeetCode Pro Subscription	Dinner for 2 up to \$100
LEGO Space Shuttle Set	Cooking knife set + \$75 doordash gift card
300 Hz Gaming Monitor	Yearly subscription to streaming service of choice
Pair of shoes of your choice up to \$200	Bronze Tier
Yearly AI Subscription of choice up to \$200	North Face Borealis Backpack
	YETI Rambler 20 oz Cocktail Shaker



Other Resources

Sponsor:

- All sponsor resources are linked [here!](#)

Full Stack:

- Mern stack: <https://www.mongodb.com/mern-stack>
- CRUD apps: <https://www.codecademy.com/article/what-is-crud>
- Building CRUD apps with MERN:
<https://blog.stackademic.com/building-a-basic-crud-using-mern-stack-7a9d951f2e02>

Backend:

- [Free cloud databases](#)
- **Staff Picks:**
 - [MongoDB](#)
 - [Firebase](#)
 - [Flask](#)

Frontend:

- [Choosing front-end frameworks](#)

AI/ML

- <https://streamlit.io/> allows you to rapidly build and showcase machine learning and data science web apps.
 - [Example](#)

Presenting & Pitching Projects

- [Helpful tips](#)
 - For our Project Showcase, timing is very important.
 - Check out the [Project Showcase section](#) to see more info.



Reimbursement Policy

For HackIllinois 2026, we are excited to offer travel reimbursements to qualifying attendees. To be considered for reimbursement, participants should have opted-in during registration for HackIllinois.

To qualify for reimbursement, attendees **must** meet the following criteria:

- Receive an acceptance to HackIllinois with a specified reimbursement amount notified in their acceptance portal.
- RSVP 'Yes' to attend HackIllinois.
- Attend HackIllinois 2026 in person.
- Submit a [qualifying project](#).

Please be aware that failing to meet any of these requirements will result in disqualification from receiving any reimbursement.

The determination of reimbursement amounts is influenced by several factors, including but not limited to an applicant's geographic location and their distance from the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign campus. Although a preliminary reimbursement amount may be indicated upon acceptance, please understand that this amount is not guaranteed and may be subject to adjustments based on the final review of eligibility criteria.

For further questions regarding travel logistics or reimbursement, please email contact@hackillinois.org.

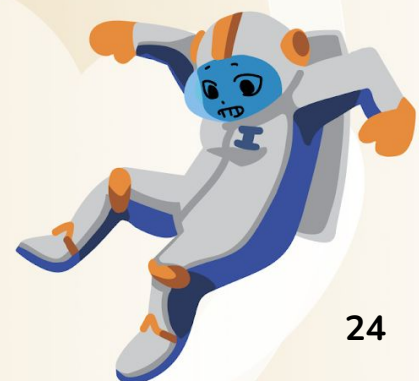


AI Policy

Use of AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Copilot, or other LLM-based tools) is allowed but transparency is required.

- You must clearly disclose any AI tools used in your project.
- Include a README section explaining:
 - Which tools you used
 - What they generated or assisted with
- Your project **must not be a simple wrapper, reskin, or minimal modification of an existing AI tool.**
- Judging will focus on what you created over the weekend, not just the tools you used.

Failure to properly credit AI usage may result in disqualification and can be reported to MLH.





Terms & Conditions

By registering for this event, you are agreeing to the HackIllinois & MLH [terms and conditions](#).

Thank you for your interest in our event! We look forward to seeing your projects, and happy coding!

Contact Information

If you have any questions, comments, or concerns during the event please feel free to reach out to us at contact@hackillinois.org, type @Help Desk in any of our Help Channels or create a ticket via Discord, or come to our in-person help desks at Siebel, located right outside of the ACM Office (1104)!

Thank You!

Thank you for taking the time to read through this guide. For more details and the official event schedule, please refer to the HackIllinois website [here](#). We hope you have an enjoyable time at HackIllinois 2026 and launch something stellar!

